aggressive steppe tribes to their north and west. The Tang capital Changan was ransacked by an army under the famous Tibetan king Srongtsen Gampo before peace was established through a treaty concluded in 821 CE .

Diplomatic missions were exchanged by the Tang with King Harsha of Kannauj. The Chinese pilgrim Xuan Zang visited India and studied at Nalanda University. After Harsha, northern India was ruled by the Gurjara Pratiharas, eastern India by the Palas and western and southern India by the Rashrakutas.

**The Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms** (907–960 CE ): The collapse of the Tang dynasty was followed by a period of extreme instability and internecine warfare. The country was fragmented into a number of smaller kingdoms and short-lived dynasties, which were eventually united under the Song dynasty. Parts of China were also invaded and occupied by tribes from Central Asia and the northern steppes.

**The Song dynasty** (960–1279 CE ): Theirs was a period of shifting fortunes, with northern China falling under the rule of the Liao, Jin and Western Xia dynasties and the Song pushed into southern China, ruling as the Southern Song.

This was the period when Muslim invasions of northern India began, culminating in the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate in 1206. In the south, the Chola empire expanded, reaching its zenith in the eleventh century.

**The Yuan dynasty** (1271–1368 CE ): A non-Han, Mongol dynasty, its rulers were descended from the conqueror Genghis Khan who established a vast Eurasian empire. After the death of Genghis Khan, the Mongol empire was split among his four sons. One line of descendants established the Yuan dynasty under Kublai Khan. Having conquered northern China, Kublai went on to defeat the Song, who had earlier been pushed into southern China by the Jin, Liao and Western Xia.

The Delhi Sultanate was now ruled by the Tughlaq dynasty (1320–1413 CE ), and under Muhammad bin Tughlaq conquered virtually the whole of the subcontinent. The break-up of the Tughlaq dynasty was followed by a patchwork of Muslim and Hindu kingdoms across the subcontinent.